In Search of Scientific Truth

Cherishing What We Do Not Know: Continuing the Search Together Rather Than Dividing Ourselves over What Is Right

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October 31, 2026

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1 Introduction

Note[1] ：*The Shigakukai Executive Committee 20th Anniversary Working Group Mr. Makoto Shimada kindly made the following request.*

> *The topic we would like Professor Suzuki to address is "Science and Faith"or "Reason and Faith."In light of social changes such as the development of social media and AI, changes in how knowledge is accumulated and how we communicate, and the resulting fragmentation of society and increased emphasis on intuition, we hope you will speak about what it means to be both a Christian and a "scientist"(not only a natural scientist, but also someone who studies the world objectively through academic inquiry).*

This is quite a challenging topic. Recently, my interests have ranged across a fairly broad set of fields, but I am not sure whether I can adequately respond to this request. Nevertheless, I would first like to express my respect and gratitude to Mr. Shimada and all the members of the Shigakukai Executive Committee for carefully considering this topic and inviting me to speak. I believe that precisely this kind of undertaking is an important part of Shigakukai.

I would like to talk a little about how I live with faith, how I use scientific thinking in that life and come to terms with it, and how I think and live as a result. I will also pose some questions to you.

Self-Introduction

Note:*Although my interests extend across many fields, they are deeply connected to the path I have followed. So I would first like to introduce myself.*

Hiroshi Suzuki (Professor Emeritus, International Christian University)

[1]Explanatory notes not included in the slides

- 1977–1980 Ph.D. program, Department of Mathematics, The Ohio State University, USA

  Afterward, I spent approximately five years in the United States, including two additional periods as a visiting faculty member and researcher. I visited around 30 churches and helped launch a ministry group for international students (IFI).

- After teaching at Osaka Kyoiku University (1980–1993), I joined International Christian University (1993–2019).
  - Taught mathematics (general education, foundational courses for science students, major courses, and graduate courses) and data science.
  - Initially worked on developing educational systems to support student learning; later, took responsibility for supporting students facing difficulties and for service learning.
  - Hosted a weekly discussion-based Bible study in faculty housing (2003–2018). My wife prepared cakes, cookies, and drinks. Eventually, 20 to 30 people attended (about two-thirds were not Christians).

    "You are welcome to say or ask anything, or to say nothing at all and simply enjoy the snacks. Everyone is welcome! I hope we can all make one another feel welcome."

    Note:*In particular, continuing the Bible study group mentioned here, in which most participants were not Christians, and what I received from that experience—although I have not yet fully processed it—has certainly become central to the way I think today.*

- Retired at age 65. In 2016, I began thinking about social changes brought about by advances in AI. While volunteering, I continued studying data science. I currently serve as a board member of a children's home (Nozomi no Ie), a vocational support facility for people with disabilities (Japan Christian Social Service), and a small regional school (Keiwa Gakuen).

Website (search for "ICU Suzuki"): https://icu-hsuzuki.github.io/

2 Science and Faith

Note:*First, I have tried to write a little, in my own way, about what it means to believe.*

Faith

What It Means to Believe

- "This is what I believe and confess"(Romans 10:9–10)
  - Behind it lie life experiences, revelation, intellectual learning, and more.
- Is what I believe also truth for others?
  - Can the grounds that guarantee its validity (the Bible, its formation and interpretation, doctrine, and personal experience)—and the resulting sense of what is right—be shared with everyone?

    → History also shows that this has led to division and conflict.
- The paths by which people are led and the grounds on which they rely differ from person to person; finding common ground can be difficult. Individual dignity and diversity
  - Alongside the importance of diversity, differences can create groups and also lead to division.
  - It is also true that the joy of being among people who share similar values can give us strength.

Romans 10:9–10
If you confess with your mouth that Jesus is Lord and believe in your heart that God raised him from the dead, you will be saved. For one believes with the heart and is justified, and confesses with the mouth and is saved.[2].

Note:*I tried to write objectively, at least to some extent, about what it means to believe because of the background of my own life journey. Perhaps the most significant influence was the student protest movement when I was in my first year of high school.*

My Younger Years

High School and University Years

- I grew up in a Christian family: my great-grandfather (from a samurai family and a judge), his mother, my grandparents, and my parents were all Christians.
- Student protest movement during my first year of high school.

  A. Under what circumstances would someone decide to break the law in order to protest what they regard as unjust?

  B. What if I had been born into a Muslim family or a family of Communist Party members?

  Note:*On Monday, October 13, 1969, several students joined forces with students from other schools and barricaded the area near the principal's office. Classes were suspended for three months. We debated almost every day. Eventually, riot police came in and the barricades were removed. When I explained my views by saying, for example, "As a Christian, I think⋯," someone asked me, "Would you think the same way if you had been born into a Muslim family or a family of Communist Party members?" I could not answer.*
- In my second year of high school, I traveled to Southeast Asia for 53 days on a cargo ship with six university students from my church.
- Attended Hi-B.A. meetings every week, and later also attended meetings of the Navigators International.
- Was a member of Tokyo Ikebukuro Church of the United Church of Christ in Japan and attended prayer meetings at Hounancho Mennonite Church.
- Read the collected works of Kanzo Uchimura and was also inspired by Hisashi Ariga's book "Do Not Regard Them as Birds in a Cage."
- While volunteering, I was invited to work in social welfare, including at a children's home. I turned down the offer and pursued graduate studies in mathematics.
- Studied in the United States and participated in launching an international student ministry organization associated with the Navigators.footnoteInternational Friendships Inc.: https://ohiostate.ifiusa.org

Note:*So, what about science?*

[2]A common confession of faith made by independent individuals

Science

Note: *What are scientific truth and scientific inquiry? This is not a lecture on the philosophy, history, or sociology of science, so I will offer only a brief overview.*

Scientific Truth and Scientific Inquiry

- Matters that can be tested through experiments and observations
  - Galileo's experiments on falling bodies; Newton's law of universal gravitation
    - Reduction of science to mathematics: deduction using mathematics (if initial conditions are given, can the future be determined?)
  - Evolutionary theory, cosmology, and quantum theory
    - Some cannot be verified experimentally; they can only be expressed probabilistically, so determinism does not apply.
- Karl Popper (1902–1994): claims that can be refuted (shown to be false) through experiments or observations (falsifiability)
  - The hypothetico-deductive method
    - Rather than induction—"observation → discovery of a theory"—science repeatedly proceeds by "formulating a hypothesis → deriving predictions from it → attempting to refute it through experiments or observations."
  - The history of science is "a process of continuous progress through theories that have survived the test of refutation."
- Debate often continues, but theories are revised and consensus gradually emerges.
  - Individual hypotheses may be disputed, but there is often no division over fundamentals, and views frequently converge.footnoteVarious approaches to the study of science have continued to develop since then.

The Validity of Science and Faith

- Can scientific knowledge be said to be absolutely correct?
  - What about evolution? How did the universe originate? Science cannot give clear answers to such fundamental questions.
  - Quantum theory and cosmology are difficult and hard to understand intuitively.
  - Falsifiability and the hypothetico-deductive method can demonstrate error, but they do not guarantee correctness.

  Note: *[Scientific knowledge] Rather than simply presenting my own understanding, I have tried to describe one possible way of looking at this, as well as what I imagine to be the perspective of the general public.*

  Falsifiability means that something can be refuted, but in practice refutation is usually not immediate. Moreover, one may be able to refute a particular claim, but once it is revised, a new attempt at refutation becomes necessary. In other words, it cannot simply be declared correct. It is an ongoing process of continual revision.

- Is what we believe[3] universally true and valid for others as well?[4]
  - Does what we believe to be right not change through experience and knowledge?
  - Is it unnecessary to engage in various forms of examination (to wrestle with knowledge)?
    - Can we explore and revise our views while acting in accordance with what we believe and value (our judgments of value)? (Philippians 3:12–13a)
  - How should we engage with the evolution of artificial intelligence (AI) and the new social changes that accompany it?

Note:*[What we believe] I mentioned that I had asked myself, "What if I had been born into a Muslim family or a family of Communist Party members?"What I can say is this:*

"Can we not continue to explore and revise our views while acting in accordance with what we believe and value (our judgments of value)?"

Philippians 3:12–13a
Not that I have already obtained this or have already reached perfection; but I press on to make it my own, because Christ Jesus has made me his own. Brothers and sisters, I do not consider that I have made it my own yet.

Different Ways of Engaging

How Should We Live as Individual Human Beings?

- Living by believing revelation, experiences of faith, and the like to be absolute truth
  - Sharing with others, with conviction and love, the truth we believe, and sharing in grace
  - A friend whose illness was healed and who lived out a steadfast faith until death
  - The many testimonies of healing at St. Thomas Church in Kerala, India

Note:*I have written a little about the life of faith. What do you think?*

- Religion: living by cherishing, with reverence, what we believe to be important
  - In the face of natural disasters, death, anxiety about an unknown future, and having nothing we can call our own, turning to the Absolute Other
  - Humbly accepting our own ignorance, limitations in ability, mental weakness, and existential vulnerability
  - Living each day to the fullest while cherishing what matters

Note:*Perhaps religion means "living with reverence by cherishing what we believe to be important."*

What do you think? The meaning of reverence may also differ from person to person in the modern world.

And living by cherishing what matters.

- Learning, exploring, and revising, as in scientific inquiry!?
  - Through the learning and experiences of everyday life, having the humility and resolve to revise, as needed, what matters to us (without shifting responsibility to others)
  - Continuing to ask ourselves what is fundamental and what matters most

What matters most to you?

Note:*And perhaps we do not understand perfectly what matters most. We probably never will.*

[3]"This is what I believe and confess"is not falsifiable; it differs from scientific truth.

[4]Others are individuals with dignity, different backgrounds and ways of thinking—diverse people created and loved by God.

3 How Should We Engage?

How Should We Engage?

Personal Convictions: What We Do Not Know (Reverence) and What We Cherish (Values)

- Becoming even a little freer from our own point of view (liberal arts)
  - Without losing the perspective of receiving God's love and living in grace through "this is what I believe and confess"
  - With the humility to be opened to the perspective of the Absolute Other and of others, becoming a little freer from self-centeredness
- Cherishing those who are important to us means cherishing the people and things that are important to them (loving ourselves and our neighbors as God loves us and our neighbors; Mark 12:28–31)dotfill The First Commandment

  Note:*I have cited Mark 12:28–31. A parallel passage appears in Matthew 22:34–40; in Luke, a somewhat different version appears in 10:25–28, before the parable of the Good Samaritan.*
  - Just as Jesus loved his disciples (and us), may we also come to love one another (John 13:34–35).
  - Not division, but peace: coming to love one another[5] (a goal and a new commandment).

  Note:*John 13:34–35 is also important. But considering how we understand "you,"and that "one another"necessarily involves another person, this is not so simple. Taken broadly, it may be an ideal or a goal.*

John 13:34–35
I give you a new commandment, that you love one another. Just as I have loved you, you also should love one another. By this everyone will know that you are my disciples, if you have love for one another.

Where I Stand Today

Note:*I wrote that religion and the life of faith mean living by cherishing what matters. Here I would like to describe where I stand today.*

Personal Concerns: What I Currently Cherish and the Challenges I See

- As a board member and volunteer at a children's home (Nozomi no Ie), a vocational support facility for people with disabilities (Japan Christian Social Service), and a small regional school (Keiwa Gakuen), I think together and cooperate with others on social issues in each setting.
  - Even in Christian institutions, nursery schools, kindergartens, schools, and hospitals, the number of Christian staff members has declined sharply.
  - The differences between urban and rural areas are significant; the difficulties faced in rural areas are particularly pronounced.
  - Although some of the values Christians have cherished are gradually shared in society, perhaps the way of life of Jesus is not being shared with society through Christians.
- Advances in AI now make it possible for individuals to study the Bible across a wide range of fields, including archaeology, biblical studies, theology, ethics, and relationships with other religions.

[5] Who is included in "us"as "those whom Jesus loved"?

  - This does not mean denying spiritual awakening or receiving revelation; it is also possible to gain a deeper understanding by making use of what is available to us.
  - We can make the fullest possible use not only of studying individual biblical passages, but also of their contexts, backgrounds of composition, relationships with other passages, and interpretations in light of historical change.

- Affirm and engage with the faith and way of life of others. Even when we cannot affirm them, maintain an attitude of listening and saying, "Please tell me about yourself,"and seek the Lord who is present behind that person.

4 To Everyone at Shigakukai

Shigakukai (An Association of Christian University Faculty and Researchers)

A Message from Me to Those Who Aspire to Learn

- Rather than asserting what is right, cherish what we do not know.
- Can we not learn to cherish diversity?
  - Engage with people of different religions, philosophies, denominations, churches, and groups, rather than becoming divided from them.
  - Foster inclusion, including people with disabilities (physical, intellectual, and mental).
  - Before nationality, gender, or cultural background, recognize the dignity of each person loved by God.
- Love one another, so that everyone will know that we are disciples of Jesus.
- Pay attention to the history of Christian churches around the world and work together to face future challenges.

Toward Learning Together and Living Together amid Diversity

- Seek a way for imperfect people to forgive one another, learn together, and accept one another.
- As individuals who bear the image of God and are loved by God, let us be enabled to witness God' s work.
- With a prayerful attitude that says, "Please teach me about yourself"(God and others).

Note:*As I have said, I do not know what matters most. Yet, particularly within the framework of the search for truth, I believe Shigakukai is truly an association of people who aspire to learn. If so, perhaps the starting point is to confess that we have not yet attained the truth.*

What do you think?